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THE EARLY OVERS ARE BITING – AND NUMBER 3s ARE BLEEDING

Data shows a **sharp decline** in returns during overs 11-20 — and number 3 batters are paying the heaviest price.

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ow long is the new ball really new?

One of the earliest calls a batter must make in a Test innings is deciding when the “new ball” can safely be treated as old. Get it right, and it sets up the chance for a big score. Get it wrong, and wickets can tumble in a heap.

The arrival of the 11th over is often seen as a key early checkpoint — the point at which the worst is presumed to have passed. But the numbers suggest this comfort may be illusory.

In 2025, batters have averaged just 28.47 in overs 11-20, with a dismissal every 52.1 deliveries. Both figures are the second lowest recorded since 2010, behind only 2024. These aren’t blips — they continue a post-2018 decline.

And the drop is most acute in this exact phase. Compared to other 10-over blocks in the first 40 overs of a Test innings, overs 11-20 have seen the sharpest fall in both average and balls per dismissal across the last three World Test Championship cycles.

What’s changed?

A deeper look at the types of deliveries bowled offers clues. There’s been a consistent decline in straight balls and a marked increase in both seam and swing movement during this phase. Batters in overs 11-20 now face more deliveries that do something — that test their judgment, technique, and trust in bounce.

